

Decolonizing HCI Across Borders

Vikram Kamath Cannanure
Carnegie Mellon University
Pittsburgh, PA, USA
kmarkiv@cmu.edu

Dilrukshi Gamage
University of Moratuwa
Moratuwa, Sri Lanka
dilrukshi.gamage@gmail.com

Christian Sturm
Hamm-Lippstadt University of
Applied Sciences
Lippstadt, Germany
christian.sturm@hshl.de

Heike Winschiers-Theophilus
Namibia University of Science and
Technology
Windhoek, Namibia
hwinschiers@nust.na

Juan Fernando Maestre
Indiana University
Bloomington, IN, USA
jmaestre@indiana.edu

Naveena Karusala
University of Washington
Seattle, Washington, USA
naveenak@cs.washington.edu

Pedro Reynolds-Cuéllar
Massachusetts Institute of Technology
Cambridge, MA, USA
pcuellar@mit.edu

Neha Kumar
Georgia Institute of Technology
Atlanta, GA, USA
neha.kumar@gatech.edu



Figure 1: HCI Across Borders held in Denver in 2017

ABSTRACT

The HCI Across Borders (HCIxB) community has been growing in recent years, starting with the Development Consortium at CHI 2016 and the HCIxB Symposia at CHI since. This year, we intend to hold an HCIxB workshop that aims to foster the scholarship potential of student and early career HCIxB researchers across the world, particularly those from and in the Global South, engaging

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on the topic of decoloniality. Through this symposium, we aim to create space for discussions that have been emerging in pockets of the HCI community, but could benefit from greater focus and attention in the interest of demarginalizing members and research areas of the community that have thus far remained on the margins of the discipline. We expect this virtual workshop at CHI 2021 to be an inaugural session for a series of virtual events that will help continue this conversation on decolonizing HCI's borders.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-centered computing → Human computer interaction (HCI).

KEYWORDS

HCIxB; decolonisation; HCI4D; decolonizing methodologies

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1 INTRODUCTION

Research in HCI today takes place in various locations across the world and speaks to a diverse audience. However, the history of HCI research, much like that of computing or design, is rooted in the Global North and addresses problems in Western contexts, making it challenging to extend this research to audiences outside of the West [22, 24]. As race [21], religion [20] and cross-cultural research [5] actively emerge as topics of HCI research and practice, it is important to recognize that these facets and what makes them different across contexts are shaped by colonial histories, which in turn influences the trajectories of HCI education, research, and design spaces. Theories on decolonial thinking provide a channel for researchers to recognize the systemic effects of coloniality and provide an avenue for building spaces for interconnected discourse about them [10, 18, 22]. Recent conversations have gathered communities to talk about decolonization in various HCI-related fields and domains, such as Computer-Supported Cooperative Work (CSCW) [23], HCI Education [6, 24], Information and Communication Technologies and Development (ICTD) [3], participatory design [8], and computing in general [7].

In the spirit of CHI 2021's focus on *Making Waves, Combining Strengths* [2], we aim to extend the conversations on decolonizing HCI to the HCIxB community. As discussed by our organizers and participants over the years [13, 14, 16, 17], "borders" may entail national/geographical boundaries but also boundaries across diverse research interests, disciplines, methodologies, and more. This year, we aim to create space for learning about avenues for decoloniality. We will reflect together on colonial differences [19] in HCI in the Global South, a concept that foregrounds the power relations that contribute to difference across contexts [19]. The goal is to align this discussion of colonial difference with Escobar's concept of the *pluriverse* of knowledge [10], where contradictory perspectives can co-exist. We hope for these discussions to support researchers looking at decoloniality in their work and to demarginalize research and researchers in our community who have thus far been relegated to the margins of HCI.

HCIxB was first organized in 2016 when a large community of researchers (70+ from 20+ countries) with ties to the Global South came together at the Development Consortium of CHI 2016 [14]. Since then, the HCIxB symposium has been organized at CHI each year. It was the largest ever in 2017 [15] when a significant amount of financial support from SIGCHI and Facebook enabled 90 participants to attend the symposium. In 2018, the symposium's focus shifted to "paving new pathways", that is, focusing on participation by and mentorship of early career researchers [16]. In 2019, the focus was on "crossing borders and intersections" [17] in order

to identify intersectionally diverse contexts where HCI research frequently takes place. Recently in 2020, HCIxB focused on the Sustainable Development Goals, bringing together domains that work on issues of sustainability [13].

This year, we expect to regroup to reflect on decolonial thinking in our research and education across borders. Through the workshop, we hope to recognize the borders that coloniality has created in computing, design, and education. Our focus on decoloniality aligns with our endeavors to support collaborations in HCI across borders and reflect on new ways to adapt HCI to broader audiences to create *pluriversal* [10] knowledge. This workshop at CHI 2021 will be the inaugural event of a series of virtual workshops that continue the conversations on decoloniality and borders in HCI among various subgroups (such as practitioners, early career researchers, regional HCI communities) throughout the year.

2 ORGANIZERS

We will recruit volunteers through our digital media channels (including the HCIxB Facebook group, established since the 2016 consortium) based on their past work and interests in decoloniality. We will also ask community leaders (such as senior researchers and practitioners or chapters) from different parts of the world to help recruit participants, to expand the discourse on decoloniality in diverse ways. We list the initial community accepted and committed to executing the HCIxB 2021 program (listed in alphabetical order of first name).

Christian Sturm is a Professor at the Hamm-Lippstadt University of Applied Sciences in Germany. His academic background includes computer science, cognitive psychology, and cultural anthropology. He has worked for several years in academia and industry in Mexico, Spain, and Egypt and taught computer science in China. His research interests include experience research and design, cross-cultural interactions, and entrepreneurship.

Dilrukshi Gamage is a Ph.D. candidate in her final year at the University of Moratuwa, Sri Lanka, with an interest in HCI, learning at scale, and MOOCs for developing countries. She has been taking part in Summer/Winter SIGCHI schools held in India, Bangladesh, and Japan.

Heike Winschiers-Theophilus is a Professor in Computer Science at the Namibia University of Science and Technology. Her work revolves around community-based co-design with indigenous and marginalised people. She is promoting a transcultural approach to tech design.

Juan Fernando Maestre is a Ph.D. candidate in Informatics at Indiana University. His research is at the intersection of HCI research methods, technology, and stigma. He applies novel methods to recruit and conduct research remotely with marginalized and vulnerable populations.

Marisol Wong-Villacres is a Ph.D. candidate in Human-Centered Computing at Georgia Tech and also faculty in the Computer Science program at Escuela Superior Politecnica del Litoral in Ecuador. Her research interests lie at the intersection of culture, learning sciences, and information access, with a specific focus on pursuing an assets-based design of technologies for vulnerable communities.

Naveena Karusala is a PhD student in the Information and Communication Technologies and Development lab at University of Washington. Her work is at the intersection of HCI and global development and looks at ways to improve health messaging by supporting the social and aspirational aspects of managing health.

Neha Kumar is an Assistant Professor at Georgia Tech, conducting research at the intersection of human-centered computing and global development. She has been involved in organizing HCIxB since 2016. Currently, she is VP-at-large of the SIGCHI Executive Committee and also serves as Chair of the ACM Future of Computing Academy.

Pedro Reynolds-Cuellar is a Colombian Ph.D student at the MIT Media Lab, affiliated with the Space Enabled Research Group. His work uses collective, participatory methods to study and document Latin American ancestral technologies and the design practices leading to their existence.

Teresa Cerratto Pargman is an associate professor at the Dept. of Computer and Systems Sciences at Stockholm University and the Dept. of Education and Communication at Jönköping University in Sweden. She conducts research in Education Technology from sociocultural and critical perspectives of human-computer interaction.

Vikram Kamath Cannanure is a Ph.D. candidate in Human Computer Interaction at Carnegie Mellon University. His research lies in building and evaluating appropriate systems for low resource contexts. He is currently working on improving teacher training in Côte d'Ivoire and providing health information in Rwanda.

3 WEBSITE

Our website¹ will be the main resource of information about the workshop. The website will include a call for participation, a list and roles of organizers, and information on prior HCIxB initiatives. We will also invite contributions to our affiliated Medium publication titled Human-Centered Computing Across Borders²; this allows authors to post from their accounts to reach a broader audience (e.g., to introduce a new project or invite collaborators openly). We will also use our Facebook group HCI Across Borders³, which now has 430+ members.

4 PRE-WORKSHOP PLANS

We plan to invite and foster participation from a broader audience generally underrepresented at CHI. We will also share readings and examples of works on our website that may shed light on the type of participation we are soliciting. Participants will be able to participate in two ways: (1) present their work in the context of decoloniality and (2) reflect on decoloniality during the workshop to engage with other participants.

We will recruit interested volunteers to serve as committee members to handle submissions, logistics, and publicity. The publicity team will distribute the call for participation on mailing lists, social media, professional networks, and the HCIxB website. We will recruit participants from other communities that cross borders within

Time	Activity
09:00 - 09:15	Welcome from the organizers
09:15 - 10:15	Introductions and paper presentations
10:15 - 10:30	Break: <i>optional—social breakout rooms</i>
10:30 - 11:00	Panel discussion
11:00 - 11:45	Breakout room discussions based on the panel
11:45 - 12:00	Break: <i>optional—social breakout rooms</i>
12:00 - 13:00	Reflections and synthesis

Table 1: Proposed Agenda for HCIxB 2021

HCI such as ArabHCI [11], Latin American HCI [12], EduCHI [9], AfriCHI [1], and many other such communities.

Participants who choose to present their work as a poster may also be asked (based on reviews) to create recorded presentations that will be shared on YouTube (with their permission). After poster decisions, we will invite all our participants to contribute to our Medium publication. Details below.

5 WORKSHOP STRUCTURE

The workshop will be held from 9 AM to 1 PM in a half-day structure (see Table 1). We will start with virtual poster presentations, consisting of two minutes where each participant will reflect on decoloniality in their work or communities, and five minutes for peer discussion and feedback. These posters will be available on Google Slides (or equivalent) to allow any participant to access and view them asynchronously. We will then have a panel discussion with experts who have backgrounds in decoloniality. The panel will be broadcast via YouTube and later embedded on the HCIxB website.

The panel will serve as a point of reflection for subsequent breakout room discussions, where groups will reflect on decoloniality and its role in supporting a pluriverse of knowledge in HCI. Following another break, we will regroup in the final session to share our key insights from the breakouts. We will spend the second half of the last session collectively synthesizing ideas into themes to consider for the future (e.g., *What would a decolonized HCI world look like? How do we get there?*). A final report will be shared as a blog post to continue the conversation with the global HCIxB community. The collaborative activities will be supported by tools such as a Miro Boards and Google Docs. Periodically throughout the workshop, we will have short breaks which can be used for informal networking.

We will post the final agenda on the website after the poster decisions.

6 DISTANCE ENGAGEMENT

This year, we plan to allow for synchronous and asynchronous participation to reach a broader audience. Discussions will be shared on social media using an appropriate hashtag (such as #DecolonizingHCIxB) to archive ideas and prompt further conversation online. We plan to broadcast and record the panel on YouTube and we will also encourage participants to share breakout room discussion notes on community Google Docs. These measures are intended to support asynchronous participation from audiences in different time zones.

¹<http://www.hcixb.org/>

²<https://medium.com/hccxb>

³<https://www.facebook.com/groups/hciXb/>

Finally, sharing the final report, as well as other artifacts such as discussion points and photos, will allow us to seek feedback from the larger community for the future of HCIXB. We also plan to use an online forum (a Discord server [4] or Slack) to allow for softer networking between participants before the workshop. We expect the online forum to allow for asynchronous participation during the workshop and act as a support channel for the community beyond the workshop.

7 POST-WORKSHOP PLANS

This year our goal is to provide opportunities for researchers across borders to reflect on decoloniality in their HCI research, education, and practice. We expect the following outcomes.

- Authors will receive feedback on their research and find mentors to support their work beyond the workshop.
- Participants in each breakout group will be invited to publish their group's emergent themes and stories as blog posts on Medium, either the Human-Centered Computing Across Borders or Voices of SIGCHI publications⁴.
- We will collectively create a final report (as a blog) for researchers across borders to reflect on colonial borders to pave way for a pluriversal HCI.
- We expect that these discussions will generate ideas for future conversations among subgroups (e.g., region-specific, early-career, etc.), which we will aim to support as separate smaller workshops throughout the year.

8 CALL FOR PARTICIPATION

The HCI Across Borders (HCIXB) workshop at CHI 2021 will be a unique venue to showcase HCI-related work from communities across geographies to a global audience. This workshop will focus on “Decolonizing HCI Across Borders”. “Borders” here may refer to national/geographical boundaries, research interests, disciplines, methodologies, and more. We invite participants to share how their education, practice, or research incorporates decoloniality. We hope to start a discussion of how decoloniality can support an HCI pluriverse where diverse voices can coexist and be heard across borders. We welcome wide participation.

HCIXB is a community developed through five years of concerted effort, focusing on connecting research and researchers on the margins across different parts of the world. It started as the Development Consortium at CHI 2016, followed by symposia at CHI 2017–2020. Today, it has evolved into a collaborative initiative with a shared mission to foster community across geographies, backgrounds, methodologies, and other borders.

Prospective participants are requested to submit a 2–4 page position paper and a short CV. The position paper should clearly outline the research questions, contributions, and impact according to the workshop theme. At least one author from an accepted paper must register for the workshop to participate. The workshop website is on <https://hcixb.org>.

⁴<https://medium.com/sigchi/tagged/voices-of-sigchi>

9 SUBMISSIONS

Those interested in participating can submit a position paper (2–4 pages, single column, PDF format preferred) and a single page CV at <https://hcixb2021.hotcrp.com>. All updates about the workshop will be available on hcixb.org. Submissions can be for (1) presentation, which requires a 2–4 page position paper that will be presented during the workshops and archived on our website, or (2) attendance, which requires a 300-word abstract to engage in a discussion on decoloniality. Below are some questions applicants may wish to consider answering in their submissions:

- Who are you? Please include your department, year of study, organization, etc.
- In what context are you working? What are the social, political, or cultural conditions there?
- What problems are you addressing? What solutions, if any, are you hoping to deliver?
- What are your project/intervention/research motivations, goals, and questions?
- What methods are you using/do you plan to use?
- What have you found thus far?
- What is novel or innovative in your approach? How does it stand apart from similar ones in the HCI world?
- How does your work align with existing work in HCI, and in particular sub-fields of HCI?
- What is the status of your project? What are the challenges and obstacles you have encountered?
- What are the expected contributions of your work?
- How do you incorporate decoloniality in your work? How do you engage with HCI to address this challenge?
- How do you think attending HCIXB 2020 will be beneficial to your work and your community?

Important Dates

- February 12: All submissions due
- March 1: Participant notifications sent
- March 31: Camera-ready versions due
- May 15: Workshop at CHI 2021

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